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MASTER KEY SYSTEM

10 People Connected to The Master Key System-and What We Can Learn from Them

Published 11 September 2026

A source-based article for independent study

Introduction

Charles F. Haanel's The Master Key System has influenced generations of readers, writers, teachers and personal-development practitioners.

First published as a correspondence course in the early twentieth century, Haanel's work explored the power of thought, concentration, visualisation, disciplined action and the relationship between the inner and outer worlds.

Although some popular claims about famous readers are difficult to verify, there are several people with strong and publicly documented connections to Haanel's ideas and teachings.

Their stories show that The Master Key System has not simply been read as a book. For many people, it has become a method of study, reflection and personal transformation.

1. Charles F. Haanel

Charles F. Haanel was the creator of The Master Key System.

He developed his teachings around the idea that thought is a creative force and that a person can change their circumstances by changing their mental habits, beliefs and actions.

Haanel emphasised concentration, silence, visualisation and the importance of applying knowledge rather than merely reading about it.

His central message was that lasting change requires disciplined practice.

2. Napoleon Hill

Napoleon Hill is one of the most important names connected with Haanel's work.

According to historical material published by Haanel-related sources, Hill wrote to Haanel in 1919 and acknowledged the importance of the principles contained in The Master Key System.

Hill later became famous for Think and Grow Rich, one of the most influential personal-development books ever written.

While the exact extent of Hill's study of Haanel's work is debated, the similarities between their teachings are clear: definite purpose, mental discipline, persistence, imagination and organised action.

3. Terry Crews

Actor, athlete and author Terry Crews has spoken publicly about The Master Key System.

He has described it as one of his favourite personal-development books and explained that it helped him understand visualisation, concentration and the importance of focusing on what he wanted to create.

Crews has also said that he returns to the book regularly.

His example demonstrates that Haanel's work continues to appeal to people who want to build discipline, confidence and a clear vision for their lives.

4. Rhonda Byrne

Rhonda Byrne, creator of The Secret, is strongly connected to the modern revival of Haanel's ideas.

The Master Key System is widely recognised as one of the influential works behind the philosophy presented in The Secret.

Both works discuss the importance of thought, belief, mental focus and the relationship between inner expectation and outward results.

However, Haanel's original work is more structured and demanding. It places greater emphasis on daily exercises, concentration and the disciplined training of the mind.

5. Anthony R. Michalski

Anthony R. Michalski is the author of The Master Key Workbook and founder of Kallisti Publishing.

He has spent many years studying and promoting the work of Charles F. Haanel.

His workbook was designed to help readers move beyond simply reading The Master Key System and begin working with its principles through exercises, questions and written reflection.

This is an important contribution because Haanel's teachings are best understood through application and repetition.

6. Robert Schmitz

Robert Schmitz is credited as a co-author of The Master Key Workbook.

His connection with the workbook helped make Haanel's principles more accessible to modern readers through structured exercises and practical activities.

The workbook format reflects an important truth about personal development: understanding an idea intellectually is not the same as practising it consistently.

7. James Allen

James Allen was a major writer in the New Thought and personal-development tradition.

Although he did not study The Master Key System-which came after much of his own work-his writings were closely connected to many of the same principles.

Allen's famous book As a Man Thinketh explored the relationship between thought, character and circumstances.

His work helped establish the wider intellectual and spiritual environment in which Haanel's teachings developed.

8. Thomas Troward

Judge Thomas Troward was one of the most important philosophical influences on Haanel.

Troward wrote extensively about Universal Mind, mental causation and the relationship between consciousness and experience.

His work is frequently discussed alongside Haanel's teachings because both writers encouraged readers to study the laws behind thought and action.

Troward's influence reminds us that the Master Key tradition did not appear in isolation. It formed part of a wider movement of philosophical and spiritual investigation.

9. William Walker Atkinson

William Walker Atkinson was a prolific writer connected with New Thought, mental science and the study of personal power.

His books explored subjects such as concentration, thought control, mental vibration and the development of individual ability.

Although a direct student relationship with Haanel cannot be firmly established, Atkinson's work belongs to the same broad intellectual tradition and shares many themes with The Master Key System.

Both writers believed that mental habits could be trained and that a person's inner life had a powerful influence on their conduct and results.

10. Henry Drummond

Henry Drummond was another writer whose ideas were connected with the intellectual and spiritual influences surrounding Haanel.

His work combined Christian thought, science, morality and human development.

Drummond's emphasis on purpose, character and the unseen forces shaping human life was compatible with many of the themes later developed in Haanel's writings.

His inclusion in discussions about the Master Key tradition shows the range of ideas that contributed to the development of early personal-development philosophy.

What These People Teach Us

The people connected with The Master Key System represent different backgrounds.

Some were direct students or modern teachers. Others were authors whose ideas influenced the same tradition. Some, such as Terry Crews, have openly described the personal value they found in the book.

Together, they reveal several important lessons.

1. Reading is only the beginning

Haanel's work was not intended to be read once and forgotten.

Its principles require reflection, repetition and practice. The reader must gradually learn to observe their thoughts, control their attention and apply the ideas to daily decisions.

2. Concentration is a practical skill

Many people are interested in visualisation and positive thinking, but Haanel placed great importance on concentration.

To concentrate is to direct the mind deliberately instead of allowing it to be controlled by distraction, fear or habit.

This is a skill that can be developed through regular practice.

3. A clear purpose changes behaviour

A definite purpose provides direction.

When a person becomes clear about what they want to achieve, their choices, priorities and daily actions begin to change.

The goal is not simply to imagine a better life. It is to use a clear mental image to guide consistent action.

4. Application creates understanding

The deepest understanding often comes after practice.

A person may read about thought, visualisation or mental discipline and believe they understand the idea. But its real meaning becomes clearer when they apply it during difficult situations, uncertainty and everyday decision-making.

5. Commitment is essential

The Master Key System is not a shortcut.

Its value depends on the seriousness and consistency of the person studying it. Those who approach it casually may gain interesting ideas. Those who study it patiently and apply it daily may experience a much deeper change in their thinking and behaviour.

Conclusion

The Master Key System has influenced a wide range of writers, teachers and practitioners for more than a century.

Some connections are historically documented, while others are based on shared ideas within the wider personal-development movement. What they have in common is a belief that the mind can be trained and that disciplined thought can influence the direction of a person's life.

The most important lesson is not simply that successful or well-known people have read Haanel.

The deeper lesson is that knowledge becomes valuable when it is studied carefully, practised consistently and translated into action.

This is the purpose of a genuine Master Key study: not to chase quick results, but to develop greater awareness, concentration, purpose and personal responsibility.

When a person commits themselves sincerely to the work, The Master Key System can become more than a book.

It can become a daily method for living with greater clarity, discipline and intention.

Sources and Further Reading

[Charles F. Haanel's history and influence](<https://www.haanel.com/history-influence/>) [Anthony Raymond Michalski's biography](<https://anthonyraymond.com/anthony-raymond-about/>) [The Master Key Mentor](<https://themasterkeymentor.com/about/>) [The Master Key Workbook on Google Play](https://play.google.com/store/books/details/The_Master_Key_Workbook_A_Complete_Method_of_Self-Mastery_by_Anthony_Raymond_Michalski) [Master Key Arcana by Anthony R. Michalski](https://books.google.com/books/about/Master_Key_Arcana.html?id=WbRIICo3HPAC)

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Published 11 September 2026. This article is based on the supplied 2026 Master Key System source material.